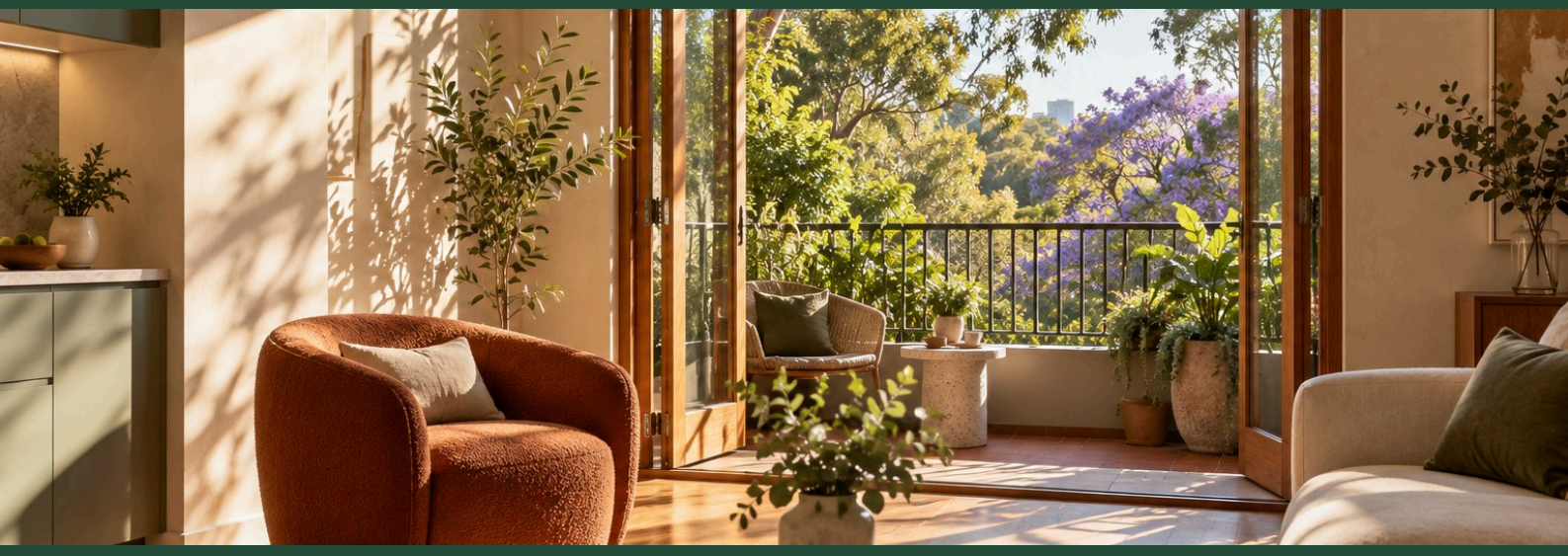
Your Property Guide

Buying a home.

From your first budget
to the day you get the keys.



A clearer way forward.

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FROM THE FOUNDER

Why I wrote this guide

Buying a home brings a lot of new information at once: borrowing limits, schemes, inspections, contracts and settlement dates. It helps to know which decisions come first, and which figures need confirming with a lender, conveyancer or inspector.

I started my career on the selling side, so I know how sales are usually prepared, priced and run. This guide explains that process from the buyer's point of view, so you can understand what you're seeing and decide at your own pace.

Chapters 1 to 3 cover where you're starting from, your budget and the schemes in your state. Chapters 4 to 7 cover choosing an area, inspecting, how homes are marketed and sold, and making an offer. Chapters 8 to 10 take you through finance, contracts, settlement and a 12-week timeline.



Andy McMaster

Founder, Your Property Guide

Where you're starting from

Everyone buys in the same market, but a first home buyer and a downsizer face different rules, risks and costs. Knowing which buyer you are makes every later decision clearer.

> SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE
>
> From the first enquiry, the selling agent is working out what kind of buyer you are, how much you can spend and how much you want this home. That's part of their job: they act for the seller and are paid to get the best result for them. If you're clear about your own situation and limits first, you can decide what to share.

Every home you look at is being sold by someone, usually with an agent who acts for the seller. The price guide, the open homes, the follow-up call and the deadline are how a sale is usually run, and together they're designed to bring the most buyers to the best price for the seller. That's the agent's job, and it helps to understand it. This guide explains how each step works, what it means for you and what to check or ask, so you can make each decision with a clear head. It starts with knowing which buyer you are.

Most buying advice is written as if every buyer were the same person: a couple in their early thirties buying a house to live in. In practice, Australian buyers split into four broad camps, and the right choice for one is often the wrong choice for another. Chapters 2 to 10 carry labelled callouts (First home, Upgrader, Investor, Downsizer) wherever the advice diverges. Find your label and read those boxes first.

The first home buyer

Your defining constraints are the deposit and the clock: prices in most capitals grow faster than most people can save. Your defining advantages are government support worth tens of thousands of dollars (Chapter 3 is yours) and total flexibility, because you have nothing to sell. Your job is to get a foothold in a sound suburb at a price the numbers support, not to find a forever home on a first-home budget.

The mistake you'll be tempted by: falling in love. It shows quickly, and a buyer who is emotionally committed, with no past purchase to compare against, finds it hardest to hold to a sensible price. Decide your walk-away number before inspecting, not during the auction.

The upgrader

You're running two transactions in the same market, which is the part most upgraders underweight. If prices move, they move on your sale and your purchase at once, so the gap between the two properties matters more than either price alone. Your equity is your biggest advantage; the sell-first-or-buy-first question is your hardest call, and Chapter 7 and our companion selling guide cover it.

The mistake you'll be tempted by: buying before you've tested what your current home is actually worth. An optimistic appraisal on the sale side plus an emotional purchase on the buy side is how families end up with bridging debt they never budgeted for.

The investor

You're not buying a home, you're buying a stream of rent and a claim on future growth, and the property doesn't need to suit you at all. Your decisions should run on yield, vacancy rates, land value and tax position. Lenders treat you differently too: higher rates, sharper scrutiny of rental income, different loan structures (Chapter 8).

The mistake you'll be tempted by: buying where you live because you know it. Familiarity is not analysis. The suburb you drive through daily is rarely the best-performing asset available for your budget, and self-managing a property two streets away turns an investment into a part-time job.

The downsizer

You're likely selling a large family home and buying something smaller, often with cash left over. You hold the strongest negotiating position of the four: no finance clause, flexible settlement, decades of market experience. Your risks are different: strata quality, lift access, proximity to services, and the gap between the home you picture and the one you'll want in ten years. Superannuation rules also give you a dedicated lever (Chapter 3).

The mistake you'll be tempted by: buying for the life you're leaving. The four-bedroom "downsize" with a guest wing for grandchildren who visit twice a year costs you exactly the windfall you downsized to collect.

One number every persona shares

Buying and later selling a property consumes roughly 7 to 10 per cent of its value in transaction costs: stamp duty, conveyancing, inspections, agent commission and marketing on the way out. That round trip is why short holds rarely pay. Whichever buyer you are, buy something you can comfortably hold for at least five to seven years, because the costs of changing your mind are steep.

7 to 10% Of a property's value consumed by a full buy-sell round trip.

> The market treats every buyer the same. Your plan should fit the buyer you are.

WATCH FOR

Persona creep. First home buyers talking themselves into "investment-grade" apartments they don't want to live in, investors keeping a dud because they once slept there, downsizers buying bigger. The moment your reasons stop matching your situation, stop and re-read this chapter.

Your checklist

- [ ] Work out which buyer you are: first home, upgrader, investor or downsizer
- [ ] Write down what you're buying and why, in two sentences
- [ ] Decide the walk-away number before you inspect anything
- [ ] Plan to hold for at least five to seven years
- [ ] Upgraders: test what your current home is worth before you buy

Build your next-step plan

Answer a few quick questions and get your next three steps, with the calculators and guides for your state.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/plan

As at mid-2026. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

Read it online: yourpropertyguide.com.au/buying-guide/which-buyer-are-you

Working out your budget

Two numbers get confused at the start of every purchase: what the bank will lend you, and what you should spend. They are rarely the same number, and the second one is yours to set.

SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE

> "What's your budget?" is usually the first question a selling agent asks. Their job is to get the best price for the seller, and knowing your pre-approval lets them pitch the price guide and any counter-offer to it. A range is a reasonable answer, and your limit can stay with you.

Your budget is one of the first things a selling agent will ask about, so it's worth setting before anyone asks. Build it from your own numbers and keep the limit private. Then every price guide you see becomes something you can test against a number you trust.

Borrowing power, and the buffer behind it

Lenders work out your borrowing power from income, expenses, existing debts and the loan you're asking for. Then they apply the rule that surprises most buyers: under APRA's serviceability standard, banks must assess you as if your interest rate were **3 percentage points higher** than the rate you'll actually pay. If your loan is offered at 5.9 per cent, you're assessed at 8.9 per cent. APRA reviewed the buffer again in 2026 and held it at 3 points, so plan around it.

3 points The APRA serviceability buffer added to your rate when banks assess you.

Three things quietly shrink borrowing power: credit card limits (lenders assess the full limit, not the balance, so cancel or cut cards you don't use), HELP/HECS repayments, and any existing loans including car finance and buy-now-pay-later accounts. Three months of clean bank statements before applying is worth real money.

Whatever number the bank produces, it is a ceiling, not a target. The bank is testing whether you can repay under stress; it is not testing whether you can repay under stress *and* have a life. Set your own

budget from your real spending, then borrow less than you're offered. Nobody has ever regretted a 10 per cent buffer of their own.

> The bank's number is a ceiling, not a target.

Deposits: 5, 10 or 20 per cent

Your deposit sets your loan-to-value ratio (LVR), and your LVR decides whether you pay **lenders mortgage insurance**. LMI protects the lender if you default; you pay the premium, and it buys you nothing. It applies once your LVR goes above 80 per cent, it scales steeply with the loan size and LVR, and most borrowers capitalise it onto the loan, which means paying interest on it for 30 years. Typical premiums on a $750,000 purchase, as at mid-2026:

Deposit	LVR	Typical LMI premium
20% ($150,000)	80%	$0
15% ($112,500)	85%	$4,000 - $8,000
10% ($75,000)	90%	$11,000 - $17,000
5% ($37,500)	95%	$22,000 - $33,000

Premiums vary by lender and insurer, so treat these as ranges, but the shape is universal: the last 5 per cent of deposit you didn't save is the most expensive money in the deal. The big exception is the federal 5% Deposit Scheme, which lets eligible first home buyers skip LMI entirely; Chapter 3 covers it. A small number of professions (medicine, law, accounting at certain income levels) can also get LMI waived at 90 per cent LVR; ask a broker if that might be you. Our LMI calculator prices it at your deposit.

The upfront costs beyond the deposit

The deposit is the headline, but settlement day has a supporting cast. Budget for all of it before you bid on anything:

- **Stamp duty (transfer duty).** The big one: a state tax on the purchase, scaled to the price. On a $750,000 established home it ranges from roughly $20,000 to $40,000 for a non-first-home buyer depending on the state. First home buyer concessions can cut it to zero (Chapter 3).
- **Conveyancing and searches: $800 to $2,500.** Contract reviews, title and council searches, settlement. Engage someone before you make an offer, not after.
- **Building and pest inspection: $400 to $800** per property you get serious about. Strata report for units: $250 to $400. Budget for two or three of these across your search; reports on homes you don't buy are the cheapest insurance in this guide.
- **Government registration fees:** mortgage registration and transfer fees, typically $200 to $500 combined depending on the state.
- **Loan costs:** application or settlement fees, $0 to $800 depending on the lender.
- **Moving, connections, immediate repairs:** $1,000 to $3,000 for most households. More if you're buying appliances or window coverings, which new builds often lack.

Worked example: a $750,000 purchase

An established house in NSW, bought two ways. Same property, very different cheques:

Upfront cost	First home buyer (5% Deposit Scheme)	Upgrader (20% deposit)
Deposit	$37,500	$150,000
Stamp duty (NSW 2026-27 rates)	$0 (exempt up to $800,000)	$27,937
Lenders mortgage insurance	$0 (government guarantee)	$0 (LVR 80%)
Conveyancing and searches	$1,800	$1,800
Building and pest inspection	$600	$600
Transfer and mortgage registration	$340	$340
Moving and connections	$1,200	$1,200
Total cash needed at settlement	**$41,440**	**$181,877**

$27,937 Stamp duty on a $750,000 established home in NSW without a concession (2026-27 rates).

The first home buyer gets in for a quarter of the upfront cash, but borrows $712,500 against $750,000 of property. A 5 per cent price dip puts that loan underwater on paper. Cheap entry is real; so is thin equity. Both columns are honest, and neither is free. Our stamp duty calculator runs the duty for your state and price.

INVESTOR

No first home concessions apply to you, so price stamp duty at the full rate, and in some states watch for surcharges (foreign-owner duty doesn't apply to citizens, but investor land tax will likely apply every year you hold). The good news: stamp duty, borrowing costs and your paid LMI all join the property's cost base or deductions. Keep every receipt from day one.

DOWNSIZER

If you're buying from sale proceeds with no loan, the buffer and LMI sections don't apply, but resist the urge to commit every dollar of the sale to the purchase. Keep a renovation and contingency fund outside the deal, and read Chapter 3 on the downsizer superannuation contribution before you decide where the leftover money lives.

WATCH FOR

Spending to your pre-approval because the number felt like permission. Pre-approval is calibrated to the bank's risk, not your plans. The buyers who get into trouble are rarely the ones the bank rejected; they're the ones the bank approved at the limit in a rising rate year.

Your checklist

- [ ] Set your own budget from your real spending, below the bank's number
- [ ] Cancel or cut credit cards you don't use, and stop buy-now-pay-later
- [ ] Price the LMI at your deposit, or check the 5% Deposit Scheme
- [ ] Add stamp duty, conveyancing, inspections and moving to the deposit
- [ ] Keep your pre-approval amount to yourself, and give agents a range

Work out your borrowing power

What lenders will let you borrow on your income, expenses and debts, with the APRA buffer applied.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/borrowing-power-calculator

LMI ranges and costs typical as at mid-2026; NSW stamp duty at 2026-27 rates. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

Read it online: yourpropertyguide.com.au/buying-guide/what-you-can-spend

CHAPTER 3 · CHECK THE SCHEMES

Schemes and concessions by state

The support on offer in 2026 is the most generous in a generation, and the most confusing. Here is the federal layer, the state layer and who qualifies for what.

> SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE
>
> Selling agents know which homes sit just under a first home buyer price cap, and that those homes draw buyers using the schemes. Pricing and marketing a home with that audience in mind is a sensible way to reach the most likely buyers. Check your caps and concessions before you inspect, so you know which homes they cover and what they're worth to you.

Selling agents know these numbers well, and it pays to know them too: they shape what you can pay, what you'll pay in duty and which homes the price caps let you buy.

The federal 5% Deposit Scheme

The headline program, formerly the Home Guarantee Scheme, was overhauled on 1 October 2025 and renamed the Australian Government 5% Deposit Scheme. The deal: you buy with a 5 per cent deposit, the government guarantees the portion of the loan above 80 per cent, and you pay **no lenders mortgage insurance**. On a 95 per cent loan that saves roughly $22,000 to $33,000 on a $750,000 purchase (Chapter 2's table).

The October 2025 reforms removed the two biggest barriers: there is **no longer any cap on places** (the old 35,000-a-year lottery is gone) and **no income test**. Property price caps still apply and were raised substantially: $1.5 million for Sydney and the major NSW centres, $950,000 for Melbourne and Geelong, $1 million for Brisbane and South East Queensland's centres, $900,000 for Adelaide, $850,000 for Perth, with lower caps outside the capitals. You must live in the home, prior property ownership rules apply, and you apply through a participating lender, not the government. One honest caveat: a guarantee is not a discount. You still borrow 95 per cent, and the repayments that come with it.

$1.5m The 5% Deposit Scheme price cap for Sydney from 1 October 2025, up from $900,000.

Help to Buy: the government as co-owner

Help to Buy is the federal shared equity scheme, launched in December 2025. The Commonwealth contributes up to 40 per cent of the price of a new home (30 per cent for an established one) in exchange for an equity stake, and you can enter with a 2 per cent deposit. It is income-tested ($103,000 for singles, $165,000 for couples and single parents, from 1 July 2026), capped at 10,000 places a year, and runs through participating lenders, initially Commonwealth Bank and Bank Australia, with more joining through 2026. City price caps apply (Sydney $1.3 million, Melbourne $950,000, Brisbane $1 million, with lower caps in the smaller capitals and regions). You repay the government's share when you sell, or buy it back in stages; the government's slice of your capital growth goes with it. For buyers locked out by repayments rather than deposit, it's the most powerful lever on this page. Read the equity mechanics carefully before signing; our Help to Buy calculator shows the shares.

The First Home Super Saver scheme

FHSS lets you make voluntary super contributions (up to $15,000 a year, $50,000 in total per person) and later withdraw them, plus deemed earnings, for a first home deposit. Because contributions can go in pre-tax at 15 per cent instead of your marginal rate, a couple can put $100,000 of deposit savings through super and come out thousands ahead of a bank account. The catches: paperwork order matters (request your determination from the ATO **before** you sign a contract), release takes weeks, and only voluntary contributions count, never the compulsory employer kind. Our FHSS calculator estimates the difference.

State grants and stamp duty relief

States stack their own help on top: a First Home Owner Grant (cash, for new builds only) and stamp duty exemptions or concessions. Settings as at 14 October 2026, checked against each revenue office:

State	First home owner grant	Stamp duty for first home buyers
NSW	$10,000, new homes to $600,000 (or $750,000 building a new one)	Exempt to $800,000, concession to $1m, new or established
VIC	$10,000, new homes to $750,000	Exempt to $600,000, concession to $750,000
QLD	$30,000, new homes under $750,000 (kept by the 2026-27 QLD Budget; eligible contracts from 20 Nov 2023)	New homes and vacant land exempt with no price cap (from 1 May 2025); established exempt to $700,000, partial to $800,000
WA	$10,000, new homes to $800,000 in Perth and the south ($1 million north of the 26th parallel)	Exempt to $600,000, then $16.15 per $100 to $800,000, new or established (agreements from 7 May 2026). Vacant land exempt to $450,000
SA	Up to $15,000, new homes, no price cap	No duty on a new home, off-the-plan apartment or land to build, no price cap. Established homes: no relief
TAS	$20,000, new homes, no price cap, for transactions 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027 (scheduled to fall to $10,000 after)	None now: the established-home exemption to $750,000 ended for settlements after 30 June 2026
ACT	No grant; concession scheme instead	From 1 July 2026, no duty at any price and no income test, if you have held no property interest in the last five years
NT	$50,000 HomeGrown Territory Grant, new homes, no price cap, contracts to 30 September 2027	No first home duty concession; the grant does the heavy lifting

Three patterns worth seeing. First, the grants chase **new builds**: governments want construction, so the cash goes to house-and-land and off-the-plan buyers. Second, the duty relief increasingly covers **established homes** too, which is where most first home buyers actually shop. Third, every scheme has eligibility fine print (residence periods, citizenship, prior ownership), and the dollar settings above change with budgets and by contract date (by settlement date in Tasmania). Verify your state's current numbers with its revenue office before you sign anything; the table is a map, not a contract. Our first home buyers hub links each state's guide.

UPGRADER

None of this chapter applies to your purchase: the schemes are strictly first-home. Two exceptions worth knowing. If your household includes someone who has genuinely never owned (a new partner, for instance), buying in their name alone can retain eligibility, with real legal and lending trade-offs that need advice. And your stamp duty bill is full freight, so weigh renovation against moving: extending costs no duty at all.

INVESTOR

Every scheme on this page requires you to live in the property, so none of them fund a pure investment. The bigger trap runs the other way: buying an investment property *first* usually extinguishes your future first-home eligibility in most schemes. If you're young and choosing between rentvesting and waiting to buy a home, price in what you're giving up: on the numbers above, it can exceed $50,000.

DOWNSIZER

Your scheme lives in superannuation: the downsizer contribution lets each member of a couple move up to $300,000 from the sale of a home owned ten years or more into super, outside the normal caps, from age 55. That's up to $600,000 of sale proceeds moved into a concessionally taxed environment. Get financial advice on timing, because it interacts with pension means tests.

Your checklist

- [ ] Check your eligibility for the 5% Deposit Scheme and its price cap for your area
- [ ] Check whether Help to Buy fits your income and the home you want
- [ ] FHSS: request your ATO determination before you sign a contract
- [ ] Look up your state's grant and duty settings with its revenue office
- [ ] Diarise the move-in and live-in dates your schemes require

See your stamp duty, with concessions

Duty for your state, price and buyer type, with the first home concessions applied.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/stamp-duty-calculator

Grant, duty and federal scheme settings checked against each revenue office and Housing Australia on 14 October 2026. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

Read it online: yourpropertyguide.com.au/buying-guide/schemes-by-state

CHAPTER 4 · CHOOSE AN AREA

Choosing an area

Where you buy does more for your result than anything you'll negotiate later, so the suburb deserves more of your time than the fridge.

> SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE
>
> A listing markets the suburb as well as the house: the school, the café strip, the growth story. That's a normal part of selling a home, and it's written to show the area at its best. Check each claim against the data, and confirm any school catchment on the education department's map rather than the flyer.

Every listing comes with a story about its suburb. Read the suburb's numbers before you read its brochure, so the area you choose rests on evidence as well as appeal.

The data that matters (and the noise that doesn't)

Suburb medians make headlines and mislead buyers. A median jumps when a few expensive homes sell and slumps when a unit block settles; it tells you what sold, not what anything is worth. The numbers that actually describe a market are the same four sellers should watch, read from a buyer's point of view:

- **Days on market.** Under 30 days, sellers have the leverage and you'll need to move fast and clean. Past 60, the leverage is yours.
- **Auction clearance rates** in auction cities. Sustained clearance above 65 per cent means crowds and overshooting guides; below 55, passed-in properties and negotiable vendors.
- **Total listings.** Rising stock month on month means more choice and softer prices. Falling stock means the opposite, whatever the headlines say.
- **Vendor discounting.** The average gap between asking and sale price. A wide gap is a market where asking prices run well above results; calibrate your offers accordingly.

All four are free on the portals' suburb pages, and our suburb profiles and suburb comparison put the rest side by side. An hour with them tells you more than a month of weekend drive-bys.

Growth signals worth trusting

Nobody reliably picks the next boom suburb, but the ingredients of growth are not mysterious:

- **Population pressure.** People arriving faster than dwellings are built. State population projections and building approval counts are both public.
- **Infrastructure that is funded, not promised.** A train line under construction moves prices; a corridor study does not. Check the project's status, not the press release.
- **Land share of value.** Land appreciates; buildings depreciate. A house where land is 60 to 70 per cent of the value has more growth engine than an apartment where it's 10 per cent.
- **The ripple effect.** Suburbs bordering an expensive one inherit its priced-out buyers. If the neighbour has run hard and yours hasn't, the gap usually closes.
- **Supply constraint.** Water, hills, heritage overlays and built-out streets limit new stock. Growth corridors with unlimited flat land must share their growth with every new estate.

School catchments: the boundary is the price

Sought-after public school catchments carry measurable premiums; buyers routinely pay 5 to 10 per cent more for an address inside the zone, and agents price accordingly. Two cautions. Check the **official** catchment map on the education department's site, not the agent's flyer, because "close to" and "zoned for" are different products. And remember boundaries get redrawn; a premium paid for a zone is a premium that can be rezoned away.

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5 to 10% The premium buyers routinely pay inside sought-after school catchments.

> Buy the suburb's trajectory, not its brochure.

FIRST HOME

When the budget forces a compromise, compromise in this order: dwelling first, position second, suburb last. A dated kitchen is fixable; a flight path is not. A modest house on a good street in a rising suburb is a better buy than a renovated one backing the arterial road, and the market knows it even when your heart doesn't.

INVESTOR

Decide the yield-versus-growth balance before you shortlist. Gross yield is annual rent over price; net yield, after rates, insurance, management and maintenance, typically lands 1 to 1.5 points lower, and strata fees drag it further. High-yield regional markets carry vacancy and single-industry risk; low-yield blue chip costs you cash flow every month while you wait for growth. Check the vacancy rate (under 2 per cent is tight) and what fraction of the suburb is renters: a deep rental market protects you between tenants. Our rental yield calculator does the arithmetic.

DOWNSIZER

Audit amenity on foot, not on the map: chemist, GP, supermarket, cafe, transport, all within a comfortable walk, plus a lift if you're above the first floor and level entry everywhere. Then audit the building as hard as the apartment: strata fees, the capital works fund balance, and the last two years of meeting minutes (Chapter 5). You're choosing the committee and the maintenance plan as much as the floorplan.

Your checklist

- [ ] Shortlist three to five suburbs from days on market, listings, clearance and discounting
- [ ] Check that the infrastructure in the growth story is funded, not just promised
- [ ] Look at land share of value, not just the median
- [ ] Confirm any school catchment on the official map
- [ ] Set portal alerts for sold prices, not just new listings

Find suburbs that fit

A 30-second quiz that scores six suburbs against your budget, your priorities and your stage.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/find-your-suburb

As at mid-2026. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

CHAPTER 5 · INSPECT WITH A METHOD

Inspecting a property

An open home is presented to look its best at a glance. Thirty careful minutes of your own checks cover most of what matters, and the right $600 report covers the rest.

SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE

Sellers present their home at its best, and their agent advises them how. Fresh paint, styled rooms, a timed open home and photos framed around the home's strengths are standard parts of a sale, and none of them is dishonest. They show you the home's best side, which is why your own 30-minute check and an independent report matter.

Experienced buyers walk through a property looking for reasons to say no. Newer buyers tend to walk through it picturing their furniture. Both notice the light and the layout; only one of them checks under the sink. The method below costs nothing and routinely saves five figures.

THE 30-MINUTE INSPECTION: 10 CHECKS

1. **Walk the outside first.** Cracks in brickwork wider than a couple of millimetres, especially stepped cracks above windows. Check where the ground drains: water running toward the house is a structural problem on layaway.
2. **Look up at every ceiling.** Stains, fresh patches of paint in one spot, sagging plaster. A roof leak repainted last week is still a roof leak.
3. **Open and close every door and window.** Sticking and uneven gaps can mean movement in the frame or footings, not humidity.
4. **Smell every room, especially wet areas.** Mould and damp announce themselves; so does the air freshener hiding them. Closed windows on a mild day are a tell.
5. **Run the taps and flush the toilets.** Water pressure, drainage speed, hot water delay. Look under sinks for swollen cabinetry and fresh silicone.
6. **Check the switchboard.** Old ceramic fuses mean rewiring money. Note the hot water system's age plate while you're there; ten years is a countdown.
7. **Press the bathroom floor and tap the tiles.** Movement, drummy tiles or spongy floors near showers point to waterproofing failure, one of the costliest defects in any home.
8. **Inspect the subfloor and ceiling cavity access.** You may only manage a glance, but a torch into the subfloor reveals damp, piers and past termite treatment plugs faster than any brochure.
9. **Audit what the photos avoided.** Wide-angle listing shots skip the neighbouring block, the power lines, the slope. Whatever wasn't photographed is your first question.
10. **Walk the street at a different hour.** Friday 5.30pm tells you about traffic and parking; Saturday 11am told you nothing. Talk to a neighbour: nobody reviews a street more honestly.

Building and pest: the best $600 in the deal

A combined building and pest inspection ($400 to $800) is a visual, non-invasive assessment by a licensed inspector: structure, roof, subfloor, moisture readings, termite evidence. Commission your own, attend in person, and ring the inspector afterwards; the ten-minute phone call is franker than the written report, which is drafted with lawyers in mind. Read the whole document, not the summary, and remember what it is not: inspectors don't open walls, move furniture or test appliances, so "no visible evidence" means exactly that.

Don’t skip the report on new builds or renovated homes; fresh paint hides more than old wallpaper ever did. And treat the seller’s own report, if offered, as a starting point rather than a substitute. It may be accurate, but the inspector was engaged by the seller and reported to them. Our building and pest inspection guide covers what to ask.

Units: the strata report is the building’s diary

For apartments and townhouses, the strata (body corporate) records search, $250 to $400, matters as much as the building report. You’re looking for: the **capital works (sinking) fund balance** against the building’s age and size; any **special levies** struck or flagged; meeting minutes mentioning water ingress, concrete spalling, combustible cladding or defect disputes with the builder; insurance currency; and the ratio of owner-occupiers to renters. A healthy building has boring minutes and a fat fund. A $400,000 unit above a $40,000-per-lot remediation problem is not a bargain at any discount.

The red flags that cost five figures

Some defects are negotiating points; some are exits. The expensive ones cluster in five families: **water** (failed waterproofing, rising damp, poor drainage; bathroom rebuilds start around $15,000), **structure** (underpinning and restumping commonly run $15,000 to $40,000), **termites** (active infestation plus structural repair regularly exceeds $20,000), **roofing** (full replacement $15,000 to $30,000), and **old services** (rewiring or replumbing a whole house, $10,000 to $25,000 each). None of these is automatically a deal-killer; all of them are deal-repricers, and the seller knows it the moment your report does.

$20,000+ What active termite damage plus structural repair regularly costs.

When to walk

Walk when the defect is structural and unquantified (no engineer’s report, no fixed price), when the seller blocks reasonable inspection access, when the strata minutes show a defect dispute with no funded plan, or when fixing the problem would cost more than the discount you can realistically negotiate. There is always another property. It rarely feels that way in the middle of a search, but it’s clear a year later.

> Every defect found before exchange is a discount. Every one found after is a bill.

FIRST HOME

The reports are where stretched budgets cut corners, and it's exactly backwards: you have the least spare cash to absorb a surprise, so you can least afford to skip the $600 that prevents one. Budget for reports on two or three properties across your search. Losing $600 on a house someone outbids you for stings; finding the restumping job after settlement costs far more.

INVESTOR

Read the report twice: once for risk, once for leverage and tax. Documented defects are your negotiation evidence (Chapter 7), and the capital works you do after settlement feed your depreciation schedule. But weigh repair downtime honestly: every week the property can't be tenanted is yield you quoted to yourself and won't receive.

Your checklist

- [ ] Run the 10-point check at every serious inspection
- [ ] Walk the street at a different hour, and talk to a neighbour
- [ ] Commission your own building and pest report, and ring the inspector
- [ ] Units: read the strata records, the sinking fund and two years of minutes
- [ ] Know your walk-away defects before you fall for the kitchen

Build your next-step plan

Tell us where you're up to and get your next three steps, with the checklists and calculators for your state.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/plan

Inspection and repair costs are typical ranges as at mid-2026. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

How homes are marketed and sold

The agent at the open home is friendly and helpful, and they act for the seller. Knowing how a sale is usually run, and what each step means for you, helps you respond calmly and decide on your own timetable.

SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE

A sale campaign is designed to bring as many buyers as possible to the best price for the seller. The price guide, the open homes, the follow-up calls and the deadline each play a part in that. Everything in this chapter is normal, legitimate selling, and knowing how it works helps you decide what to share and when to act.

Start with the basic fact of every sale: **the agent works for the seller**. Their legal duty is to the seller, and their commission depends on the seller's result. That's how the role is meant to work, and none of it makes the agent your opponent. It does mean the advice you hear at an open home is given on the seller's behalf, so it helps to understand how a sale is put together.

How a sale is usually run

Most homes are sold through a marketing campaign, and our selling guide explains how sellers plan one. For a buyer, it usually arrives in four stages, and each one asks something of you:

- **The number.** Before launch, the agent sets a price guide or an advertised price. It's a marketing tool designed to bring in the right buyers, not a valuation (more below).
- **The launch.** A new listing gets its biggest audience in its first two weeks, when every buyer with a saved search is notified. The campaign aims to turn that interest into offers quickly, which is why the first fortnight feels the most urgent.
- **The opens and the follow-up.** A busy open home shows every buyer there that they have competition, and the follow-up call is where the agent learns your budget, your timeline and how much you want the home.
- **The deadline.** An auction date or a "best and final" call. Deadlines are the campaign's strongest tool, because they ask you to decide on the seller's timetable rather than your own.

Knowing which stage you're in tells you what the agent is likely to ask of you next, and what you may prefer to keep to yourself.

Price guides and underquoting

A price guide is a marketing tool, not a valuation. Quoting low pulls a bigger crowd, and a bigger crowd makes a better auction, so guides in hot auction markets routinely finish 10 per cent or more below the result. The states have rules (in NSW the advertised guide can't sit below the agent's written estimate in the agency agreement; in Victoria every listing needs a Statement of Information with an indicative price backed by three comparable sales), but enforcement focuses on the worst cases, not the everyday gap between guide and result. Our guide to underquoting laws by state has the detail.

The practical response is to build your own estimate and treat the guide as a starting point. Pull the three comparables from the Statement of Information or ask the agent directly which sales support the guide, then check what those properties actually sold for. If the guide doesn't line up with its own evidence, price the property yourself: recent settled sales of genuinely similar homes within a kilometre, adjusted for land, condition and street. Chapter 2 of our selling guide describes how sellers and agents work out a realistic price; it's worth building the same estimate yourself.

Watch how the guide moves during the campaign too. A guide that creeps upward mid-campaign ("buyer feedback has been strong") is telling you the interest is real. A guide that holds while open-home numbers thin is telling you the opposite, even if the agent sounds upbeat on Saturday.

What agents often say, and how to respond

- **"What's your budget?"** A normal question, and your answer is valuable to the seller. Answer with a range that starts at your hoped-for price, or say it depends on the property. Keep your limit to yourself.
- **"We have another very interested buyer."** Possibly true, and hard for you to verify either way. Respond to evidence (a contract issued, a building report ordered), not adjectives.
- **"The vendor would consider offers around $X."** A way of testing where buyers sit. The figure is usually set above the lowest price the seller would accept. Respond with your own evidence rather than starting from their number.
- **"Make your best and final offer."** Sometimes a formal multiple-offer process, sometimes a way to bring a negotiation to a close. Ask how offers will be presented and whether the process is in writing. A genuine process has a clear answer.

- **“It will be sold by the weekend.”** Maybe. Properties do come back after “sold by the weekend”, and if this one sells, it won’t be the last good house in Australia.

One more thing to know: agents keep notes on the buyers they meet, usually in a database, and what you share can follow you to the next listing. Your budget, your urgency, your personal circumstances, your lease ending in March. Be polite and engaged, and keep personal details to yourself.

> Understand how the sale works, and you can decide at your own pace.

How auctions are run

An auction is designed to build competition: the crowd shows buyers there is interest, the auctioneer keeps the bidding moving, and the contract is final (no cooling-off at auction in any state or territory; Chapter 7). Auctioneers use a few standard techniques: a “vendor bid” to start the bidding, calls for raises in $5,000 steps that feel small against the price of a house, and a long pause before “passing in” that gives the room one more chance to bid. Knowing how it works helps, but the moment still carries people along, which is why your limit is best set at home, in writing, before you register (Chapter 7 covers how to bid).

Before auction day, the agent may invite pre-auction offers (“the vendor will sell before Saturday for the right number”). Sometimes the seller will genuinely sell early; often an early offer helps set a floor under the auction. If you offer early, make it strong enough to end the campaign, give it a short expiry, and expect the agent to test it with other buyers.

Off-market: the quiet listing

An off-market sale skips public advertising: the agent offers the property to their own buyer database. From the seller’s side, the pitch is privacy and speed; the cost is that price discovery needs exposure, and an off-market sale has the least. For a buyer, that cuts both ways. There’s no visible competition, which can work in your favour. But sellers also use a quiet fortnight as a pre-launch test run, so your offer may be the evidence that sets the public price.

How to respond:

- Price it from settled comparable sales exactly as you would a public listing. “Exclusive access” is not worth a premium.

- Ask how long it has been offered, and whether a public campaign follows if it doesn't sell quietly.
- Put your offer in writing with a short expiry, so it doesn't stay open while the agent tests the market.

Days on market: what a listing's age tells you

Sellers watch how long their home has been listed, and you can watch it too: listing date, price-cut history and previous campaigns are all visible on the portals or a sixty-second search. A fresh listing in week one or two has a confident vendor who rarely negotiates hard. The same listing at day 70, after one price cut and a relisted campaign, has a vendor whose agent is now managing *their* price expectations. That is when conditional offers, longer settlements and sharper prices tend to be accepted.

60 days Past this many days on market, the negotiating leverage usually sits with buyers.

How to respond: your own plan

The seller's sale runs to a plan. Your purchase can too, and it only needs to be in order:

1. Build your own estimate from settled sales before you read the guide.
2. Give the agent a range, and keep your limit and your pre-approval amount to yourself.
3. Track every shortlisted home's guide against its result; that gap is your suburb's quoting habit.
4. Respond to evidence, not adjectives, and put every offer in writing with an expiry.
5. Use the calendar: fresh listings for certainty, older ones for room to negotiate.
6. Set your auction limit at home, in writing, before you register.

FIRST HOME

Urgency is felt most by buyers who've missed out before. Two rules help: keep your pre-approval amount to yourself (it is your ceiling, and what you share with one agent can travel), and don't make a same-day offer you hadn't planned that morning. A home that can't wait for a single night's sleep was unlikely to be the right decision.

INVESTOR

Your advantage is that a spreadsheet doesn't feel the pressure of an open home. Use that openly: tell the agent you're a numbers buyer with finance arranged, ask for the rental appraisal and outgoings up front, and make offers that expire. Agents weigh certainty as well as price when they advise a seller, so a calm buyer with clean terms is often preferred over a higher, less certain offer.

Your checklist

- [ ] Build your own price estimate from settled sales before you read the guide
- [ ] Track each shortlisted home's guide against its result
- [ ] Answer "what's your budget?" with a range rather than your limit
- [ ] Weigh evidence (contracts issued, reports ordered) over adjectives
- [ ] Off-market: price it from comparables and ask if a public campaign is coming
- [ ] Check days on market and price cuts before you negotiate

Have someone act for you

A buyer's agent acts for you, not the seller. Where one takes part in your area, we'll introduce you, and we'll tell you plainly if we can't.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/get-help

Underquoting rules and auction settings as at mid-2026. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

Read it online: yourpropertyguide.com.au/buying-guide/how-the-selling-side-plays-you

Making an offer

Price gets the attention, but an offer is a package: price, conditions, deposit and settlement. Thinking through all four gives you more ways to reach a deal that works for you.

SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE

> The selling agent's job is to get the seller the best price and terms, so they will weigh your offer against other buyers' and against the lowest price the seller will accept. Your written offer may be used to seek a better one from other buyers. A clear offer, backed by evidence and with an expiry, gives the seller something concrete to decide on.

This is where the seller's plans and yours meet. The selling agent is aiming for the best price on a timetable that suits the seller; you want the right price on terms that protect you. Go in with your numbers written down and your offer on paper.

Private treaty: the negotiation

Before you offer, you need three numbers written down: your evidence-based value (from comparable settled sales, not the guide), your opening offer, and your genuine walk-away. The discipline isn't the arithmetic; it's refusing to revise the walk-away mid-negotiation because the kitchen was nice.

Open below your value but inside credibility: roughly 5 per cent under in a balanced market, more if the listing is stale (Chapter 6), less in a hot one. Lowball offers 15 per cent under don't anchor anything; they usually tell the agent you're not a serious buyer. Put the offer **in writing** with your conditions, your deposit and your settlement terms stated, give it an expiry (48 to 72 hours keeps a process honest), and justify the number with two or three comparable sales. An offer with reasons is harder to dismiss than a number on its own.

Expect a counter-offer, and be careful with the most common shortcut: splitting the difference. "You're at $720,000, they're at $740,000, let's do $730,000" costs you $10,000 in one agreeable sentence. Counter in smaller steps, without rushing, and give your reasons. And use terms as currency: a settlement date that suits the vendor, a bigger deposit, a shorter finance period. Terms regularly buy what cash can't. Our guide to negotiating the price has worked examples.

The conditions that protect you

- **Subject to finance.** Your right to exit, deposit intact, if your loan isn't formally approved within a stated period (14 to 21 days is standard). Pre-approval does not make this clause redundant: final approval depends on the bank valuing *this property* (Chapter 8). Waive it only with unconditional approval in writing.
- **Subject to building and pest.** Your exit, or in practice your renegotiation lever, if the inspection finds material defects. In hot markets buyers waive it to look strong; that is exactly the market where defects can go unnoticed behind fresh paint.
- **Subject to sale** of your own property: the weakest condition you can attach, and many sellers won't take it. If you need it, you're usually better selling first (Chapter 1's upgrader problem).

In some states conditions are standard contract furniture (Queensland's standard contract has finance and building-and-pest clauses built in); in NSW and Victoria they're negotiated specially. Your conveyancer inserts them **before** you sign, which is why they're engaged in week one, not after the handshake.

Deposits and exchange

The deposit (10 per cent by convention, 5 per cent commonly negotiated) is paid when contracts are exchanged and held in trust, almost always the agent's trust account, until settlement. It is not extra money; it's the first slice of your purchase price. Exchange is the moment the deal binds both sides, and in NSW and the ACT there's a gap between the handshake and exchange in which you can be **gazumped**: the seller can legally take a better offer until contracts are exchanged. The protection is speed: contract reviewed early, deposit ready, and a fast exchange asked for. In cooling-off states you can sign quickly and let the cooling-off period (Chapter 9's table) do the protecting; withdrawing inside it costs 0.25 per cent of the price in NSW, a fair premium for locking the door behind you.

Bidding at auction: decide beforehand, bid calmly

Everything about auctions flows from one legal fact: **the successful bid is unconditional, and there is no cooling-off at auction in any Australian state or territory**. No finance clause, no inspection clause, deposit due on the spot. In Victoria the exclusion extends to private sales within three clear business days either side of a publicly advertised auction. So every protection has to happen before the hammer: contract reviewed by your conveyancer, building and pest done, strata report read, finance formally approved with the bank's valuation completed, deposit cheque or transfer arranged.

0 days

Cooling-off after the hammer falls, in every state and territory.

On the day, how you bid matters less than folklore says, but it still matters:

- **Set your limit in writing before you leave home**, an odd number ($861,500 rather than $860,000, because limits cluster at round numbers and yours clears the cluster).
- **Bid clearly and without hesitation.** Projecting calm certainty discourages marginal bidders. Whether you open early or wait, bid like someone who intends to buy.
- **Set your own increments.** You can offer less than the auctioneer calls for; slowing $10,000 steps to $2,500 late in the auction slows the momentum and shows who is near their limit.
- **Know the pass-in rules.** If bidding stalls below reserve, the highest bidder usually earns the first (and sometimes exclusive) right to negotiate immediately afterwards. Being that bidder at a low number is a strong place to stand; brief yourself on your negotiation floor before the auction, not in the huddle.
- **Vendor bids must be announced** by the auctioneer. Hearing one late in the auction tells you the bidding from buyers hasn't reached reserve. That is useful information; factor it in.

> An auction limit set in the moment is not a limit.

FIRST HOME

Your pre-auction bill is real: a contract review, a building and pest report and possibly a strata search on a property you may not end up buying, multiplied by every auction you attempt. Budget for it, and use it as a filter: if you wouldn't spend $800 preparing, you don't want the property at auction prices. Some buyers split costs by negotiating report access with other bidders; fine, but read the assignment terms.

DOWNSIZER

You are often the strongest buyer in the room and the least inclined to say so. Say so. No finance condition, flexible settlement, rent-back offered if the vendor needs time: sellers routinely prefer that package to higher offers from conditional buyers. Put your terms in the written offer, not only the conversation, so the agent presents them to the vendor in full.

WATCH FOR

Pre-auction offers invited by the agent (“the vendor will sell before Saturday for the right number”). Sometimes the seller will genuinely sell early; often an early offer helps set a floor under the auction. If you offer pre-auction, make it strong enough to end the campaign, with a short expiry, and expect the agent to test it with other buyers. A weak pre-auction offer mostly tells the seller what you’re prepared to pay.

Your checklist

- [ ] Write down your value, your opening offer and your walk-away
- [ ] Offer in writing, with conditions, deposit, settlement terms and an expiry
- [ ] Justify the number with two or three comparable sales
- [ ] Keep finance and building-and-pest conditions unless you truly don’t need them
- [ ] Auction: reports done, finance approved and limit set in writing before you register

Check what the offer costs you each month

Repayments, deposit and upfront costs at the price you’re about to offer, before you put it in writing.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/affordability-calculator

Cooling-off and auction rules as at mid-2026. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

Read it online: yourpropertyguide.com.au/buying-guide/making-an-offer

CHAPTER 8 · FINALISE YOUR FINANCE

Finance and approval

Pre-approval feels like a green light. It's a strong maybe with an expiry date, and the gap between the two is where purchases fall over.

SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE

A finance condition is a risk for the seller: if your loan falls through, so does the sale. That's why selling agents ask about your finance, and why they tend to favour buyers whose approval looks certain. A fully assessed pre-approval and a short finance period make your offer easier for the seller to accept.

Finance is the part of your purchase the selling agent can't see but will always ask about. Make it certain, and you can move faster and negotiate with more confidence than buyers whose approval is still a maybe.

What pre-approval is, and isn't

Pre-approval (conditional approval) is a lender's in-principle agreement to lend you up to a stated amount, subject to conditions, always including a valuation of whatever property you eventually buy. Get it before you shop seriously: it fixes your real budget, marks you as a credible buyer, and finds problems while they're fixable. But know its limits. Some "pre-approvals" are system-generated in minutes without a human reading your documents; ask whether yours was **fully assessed by a credit officer**, because the unassessed kind collapses at the worst moment. And it typically **expires after about 90 days**. Renewing is usually straightforward, but it's a fresh assessment: if rates have risen or your circumstances changed, the number can come back smaller. Our pre-approval guide covers the paperwork.

90 days The typical life of a pre-approval before it expires and must be reassessed.

Between pre-approval and final approval, live like the application is still open, because it is: don't change jobs if avoidable, don't take on new debt or raise card limits, don't make patterns of unexplained

spending, and don't lodge applications with multiple lenders for sport, since every hard enquiry lands on your credit file.

Valuation shortfalls: the quiet deal-killer

Final approval hinges on the lender's valuation of the specific property. Banks lend against the **lower** of price and valuation, so if you contract at $800,000 and the valuer says $760,000, your 80 per cent loan just shrank by $32,000, and the gap comes from your pocket. Shortfalls cluster in fast-moving markets (valuations look backward at settled sales; you bid forward), off-the-plan purchases, and unusual properties with thin comparables.

If it happens: ask the broker to **challenge the valuation** with better comparables (it sometimes works), order a valuation through a second lender (valuers differ more than banks admit), renegotiate the price with the valuation as evidence, or exit under your finance clause. Every one of those options is better than the fifth, which is finding the gap on a credit card. If you bought at auction with no finance clause, the gap is simply yours; re-read Chapter 7's pre-auction checklist.

> Banks lend against the lower of price and valuation. The gap is yours.

Investor lending: a different counter

Investment loans run on harsher settings than owner-occupier loans, and pricing your purchase on owner-occupier assumptions is a rookie error:

- **Rates run higher**, typically 0.2 to 0.6 percentage points above comparable owner-occupier loans, with interest-only versions higher again.
- **Interest-only periods** (commonly five years) maximise deductible interest and cash flow, but you're assessed on your ability to repay principal over the *remaining* term, which cuts borrowing power, and the repayment jump at the end of the IO period is real.
- **Rental income gets shaded:** most lenders count only about 80 per cent of expected rent, to allow for vacancy and costs, and then add their own estimates of expenses on top. Your spreadsheet says the rent covers the loan; the bank's says otherwise, and the bank votes.

Structure matters more for investors than anyone: loan splits, offset placement, and keeping investment debt cleanly separate from private debt all have tax consequences. Get the structure advice *before*

settlement; restructuring afterwards ranges from expensive to impossible.

Broker or direct?

Roughly three in four new Australian home loans are now written through mortgage brokers, and the logic is plain: one application, dozens of lenders, and the broker is paid commission by the lender rather than by you. Brokers also carry a legal **best interests duty** to you; a bank's own lending staff carry no such duty and can only ever offer that bank's products. The counterweights: a broker's panel doesn't include every lender, commission structures can subtly favour some products, and a mediocre broker is worse than a good bank banker. Going direct can work better when you have a strong existing banking relationship or a lender outside broker panels. Whichever path, compare at least two offers, and ask the broker straight: "Which lenders pay you most, and is one of them this recommendation?" Good ones answer without blinking.

FIRST HOME

The 5% Deposit Scheme and Help to Buy run through participating lenders only, and not every bank participates, so scheme eligibility narrows your lender list before rate shopping starts. A broker who writes scheme loans weekly will know which lenders are fast, which price scheme loans competitively, and which drown applicants in paperwork. Ask specifically about scheme experience when choosing one.

UPGRADER

Don't default to your current lender out of loyalty; the refinance market prices loyalty at zero. But beware **cross-collateralisation**: letting one bank secure the new loan against both your old and new homes ties the properties together, complicates your sale and hands the bank all the leverage. Keep the loans clean and separate, even if it means more paperwork during the changeover.

DOWNSIZER

If you need a loan at all (to bridge between buying and selling, or to top up), expect age to enter the assessment: lenders must see a credible exit strategy for any loan extending past retirement income. Bridging finance works but compounds interest on the combined debt, so get it modelled before you commit, and treat a long settlement on your purchase (Chapter 7) as the cheaper alternative it usually is.

Your checklist

- [ ] Get a pre-approval that a credit officer has fully assessed
- [ ] Diarise its expiry, usually about 90 days
- [ ] Don’t change jobs, take on debt or raise card limits until settlement
- [ ] If the valuation falls short, challenge it before the finance clause expires
- [ ] Investors: settle the loan structure before settlement, not after

Price the LMI before you sign

What lenders mortgage insurance costs at your deposit and loan size, and how much a bigger deposit saves.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/lmi-calculator

Lending settings as at mid-2026. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

Read it online: yourpropertyguide.com.au/buying-guide/finance-to-unconditional

CHAPTER 9 · GET TO SETTLEMENT

Contracts, cooling-off and settlement

The weeks between signing and settlement are quiet when everything goes right. Here is what your conveyancer does, what you need to do, and the one inspection that still matters.

> SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE
>
> After exchange, the selling agent's job is to get the sale to settlement smoothly for the seller. They still act for the seller, and they'll usually be your contact for the final inspection and the keys. Your conveyancer and your own final inspection are what look after your interests.

Once the contract is signed, most of the selling agent's work is done. Yours isn't. These weeks are where buyers lose money to missed deadlines and unchecked inclusions, so treat them as carefully as the search.

Conveyancing: hire early, use properly

A conveyancer or property solicitor ($800 to $2,500 for a standard purchase) reviews the contract, runs the searches, manages conditions and deadlines, and executes settlement. The single most valuable thing they do costs the least: the **pre-signing contract review**, often $200 to $400 if charged separately. It catches the special condition that waives your rights, the easement through the backyard, the sunset clause in the off-the-plan contract, the inclusions list missing the dishwasher you shook hands over. Engage them in week one of your search and send every contract you get serious about. Solicitors over conveyancers when anything is non-standard: trusts or SMSF purchases, off-the-plan, disputes, or anything involving the word "unusual" from your own conveyancer. (In Queensland, conveyancing is done by solicitors as standard practice; in WA, settlement agents are the local equivalent.) Our conveyancing guide covers what to ask.

Cooling-off: your exit window, state by state

In most states, a buyer who signs a private treaty contract for residential property gets a short statutory window to withdraw, for a small penalty or none. It exists so a rushed signature isn't a life sentence; it is

not a free option to keep shopping. It never applies to auction purchases, and it can be waived (in NSW via a section 66W certificate from your solicitor) or shortened by agreement.

State / territory	Buyer cooling-off period	Cost to withdraw
NSW	5 business days (10 for off-the-plan)	0.25% of purchase price
Victoria	3 business days	$100 or 0.2%, whichever is greater
Queensland	5 business days	Up to 0.25%
South Australia	2 clear business days (runs from Form 1 service if later)	Deposit above $100 refunded
Western Australia	None (unless written into the contract)	n/a
Tasmania	None (unless written into the contract)	n/a
ACT	5 business days	0.25% of purchase price
Northern Territory	4 business days	None; deposit refunded in full

In WA and Tasmania there is no statutory window at all, so every protection must be a written condition in the contract before you sign. Treat the table as the default and confirm current rules when you sign; these settings get amended. Our guide to cooling-off periods by state has the detail.

Exchange to settlement: the quiet checklist

Settlement is negotiated in the contract: around 30 days is common in Queensland, 42 days (six weeks) the default in NSW and Victoria, with 30 to 90 days the practical national range. Between exchange and settlement day:

42 days The default settlement period in NSW and Victoria; about 30 in Queensland.

- **Get finance to unconditional** inside the clause period, in writing, and have your conveyancer confirm it to the other side. Silence past the deadline puts your deposit at risk.

- **Insure the building from exchange.** In Queensland, risk formally passes to the buyer shortly after signing; elsewhere it generally stays with the seller until settlement, but the cheapest certainty in this list is holding cover from exchange everywhere. Strata buildings carry their own insurance; you insure contents.
- **Sign and return everything fast.** Transfer documents, your lender's loan pack, identity verification. The most common cause of delayed settlements is paperwork sitting in someone's inbox, and in most states the party who can't settle on time pays penalty interest.
- **Book the practical life admin:** removalists, utility connections for settlement day, mail redirection, and your state revenue office concession paperwork if you're claiming one (your conveyancer usually lodges duty and concessions for you).

The final inspection: use it

You're entitled to a pre-settlement inspection, usually in the final week, booked through the agent. You're confirming the property is in the same condition as at sale and every contractual inclusion is present and working: light fittings, dishwasher, curtains, pool equipment, the shed contents you negotiated. Run taps, test appliances, open every door. If something's wrong, don't accept the keys-and-promises version; call your conveyancer the same day. The remedies (a settlement adjustment, money held in retention, or a short delay) all work vastly better *before* the money moves. After settlement, you're chasing a stranger for a favour.

> Settlement day is boring when everyone has done their job. Aim for boring.

Settlement day

Almost everything happens electronically through PEXA or an equivalent platform, attended by the conveyancers and lenders rather than you. In sequence: your lender draws down the loan, your funds and theirs settle against the seller's mortgage discharge, stamp duty is paid, rates and water are adjusted to the day, the transfer is lodged and the title moves. Your conveyancer phones you, the agent releases the keys, and the property is yours, usually by mid-afternoon. Keep the settlement statement and contract permanently; if the property ever produces income, your accountant will want them decades from now.

INVESTOR

If the property comes with a tenant, the lease survives settlement and so do its terms; you inherit the rent, the bond and the condition report, so have your conveyancer verify all three before settlement. Appoint your property manager before settlement day, and order a **tax depreciation schedule** (around $600 to $800, itself deductible) immediately after it. Rent is apportioned at settlement like rates, so check the adjustment statement.

FIRST HOME

Your concessions get actioned here: the conveyancer lodges the stamp duty exemption paperwork, and any grant for a new build is typically paid through your lender at settlement. Most schemes then require you to **move in within 12 months and live there for a minimum period** (commonly 6 to 12 months, varying by state and scheme). Renting it out early can mean repaying the lot, plus penalties. Diarise the dates.

Your checklist

- [ ] Send every serious contract to your conveyancer before you sign
- [ ] Know your state's cooling-off rules, and that auctions have none
- [ ] Get finance unconditional inside the clause period, in writing
- [ ] Insure the building from exchange
- [ ] Use the final inspection: test everything, report problems the same day

Build your next-step plan

Your next three steps for where you're up to, with the checklists and calculators for your state.

yourpropertyguide.com.au/plan

Cooling-off settings as at mid-2026. These get amended, so confirm the current rules when you sign. General information only, not financial, legal or tax advice. Costs, rules and timeframes vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change. Check the current rules for your state before you act.

Read it online: yourpropertyguide.com.au/buying-guide/contracts-to-keys

Your 12-week buying timeline

Print this page. Twelve weeks from first broker call to exchange is realistic for a prepared buyer, with settlement following four to six weeks later.

SEEING IT FROM THE SELLER'S SIDE

Every sale campaign runs to a schedule: a launch date, open-home weekends and a deadline. Agents plan it that way so interested buyers look at the same time and the seller can weigh offers together. With a timeline of your own, their dates arrive when you're ready rather than as emergencies.

Every sale runs to a schedule, and your purchase can too. Here it is week by week; tick each one off as you go.

When	What to do	Done
Week 12	Set your real budget from your own spending, not a calculator. Pull three months of statements, cancel unused credit cards, stop the buy-now-pay-later. Work out which buyer you are (Chapter 1) and write down what you're actually buying and why.	☐
Week 11	Talk to a broker (or two lenders direct). Check your scheme eligibility (Chapter 3) and confirm which lenders participate. Lodge your pre-approval application, fully assessed, not the instant kind. First home buyers using FHSS: request your ATO determination now.	☐
Week 10	Engage your conveyancer or solicitor. Shortlist three to five suburbs using the data in Chapter 4: days on market, listings, clearance, discounting. Set up portal alerts for your brief, including "sold" alerts to track real prices.	☐
Week 9	Pre-approval in hand. Start inspecting, two to four properties a weekend, to calibrate your eye. Track every shortlisted property's guide against its eventual result; the gap is your suburb's quoting habit, and you'll use it in every negotiation.	☐
Week 8	Keep inspecting and recording. Walk your shortlisted streets at different hours. Practise the Chapter 5 checklist until it's automatic. Refine the brief: what you thought you wanted and what you keep walking into are rarely the same property.	☐
Week 7	Serious candidates emerge. Request contracts, send them to your conveyancer for review, and build your comparable-sales file for each. Decide your evidence-based value before asking the agent anything that reveals yours.	☐
Week 6	Order building and pest (and strata search for units) on the front-runner. Ring the inspector after reading the report. Re-confirm your pre-approval is current and covers this property type and postcode; some lenders restrict both.	☐
Week 5	Make your written offer with conditions, deposit, settlement terms and an expiry (Chapter 7). Auction buyers: contract reviewed, reports done, finance formally approved, limit set in writing. Negotiate from your file, not the guide.	☐
Week 4	Agree terms and exchange contracts. Pay the deposit into the trust account. Cooling-off runs if your state has one (Chapter 9). Notify your lender the moment contracts exchange so the valuation and formal approval start immediately.	☐
Week 3	Finance goes unconditional inside the clause period; chase it daily near the deadline. Insure the building from exchange. If the valuation falls short, work through the Chapter 8 options before the clause expires, not after.	☐
Week 2	Conveyancer prepares transfer and settlement figures. Sign and return your loan documents the day they arrive. Book removalists and utility connections for settlement day. First home buyers: confirm duty concession paperwork is lodged.	☐

When	What to do	Done
Week 1	Final inspection through the agent: same condition, every inclusion present and working. Report problems to your conveyancer the same day. Confirm settlement time, key handover and your cleared funds position.	☐
Settlement day	Settlement completes electronically; duty paid, title transferred, balance drawn from your lender. The agent releases the keys, usually mid-afternoon. Keep the settlement statement and contract permanently. Change the locks tonight; you have no idea who has keys.	☐

The twelve weeks compress or stretch with your market: hot suburbs can demand a bid in your first fortnight of looking, and slow ones reward another month of patience. The order, though, barely changes: arrange finance before you shop, gather evidence before you offer, and get the reports before you sign.

12 weeks

First broker call to exchange, for a prepared buyer.

PERSONA FOOTNOTES

First home: add two to four weeks at the front for scheme paperwork and FHSS release; both move at government speed. **Upgrader:** run our 12-week selling timeline in parallel, offset so your sale exchanges first, and negotiate long settlements on both sides to make the bridge. **Investor:** add property manager selection in week 2 and the depreciation schedule at settlement; skip the street-walking, double the spreadsheet time. **Downsizer:** let the timeline stretch; your strength is that you don't have to buy this one, and long settlements are yours to offer or ask for.

Your checklist

- [ ] Print the timeline and put a date against each week
- [ ] Lodge a fully assessed pre-approval in week 11
- [ ] Engage your conveyancer in week 10, before you inspect seriously
- [ ] Track guides against results from week 9
- [ ] Have finance, reports and your limit ready before any offer or auction

Build your next-step plan

Your next three steps for where you're up to right now, with the tools and guides for your state.

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Read it online: yourpropertyguide.com.au/buying-guide/buying-timeline

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Your Property Guide helps everyday Australian homebuyers and sellers understand the costs and choices ahead: free guides, calculators and next-step plans for buying, selling or both. When you ask, we can introduce a participating selling agent, or a buyer's agent where one is available, one for each service you request. The agent pays us a flat fee for the introduction. We take no share of their commission, you pay us nothing, and the fee doesn't change what you pay the agent.

You'll find this guide online chapter by chapter, its companion guide, Selling a home, and every calculator at **yourpropertyguide.com.au**.

DISCLAIMER

This guide is general information only. It is not financial, legal or tax advice, and it doesn't take your personal circumstances into account. Costs, scheme settings, grant amounts, price caps, legal requirements and timeframes are typical figures as at mid-2026 (first home grants, stamp duty relief and federal scheme settings checked 14 October 2026); they vary by state, suburb and situation, and they change with budgets and legislation. Before acting on anything in this guide, verify the current rules for your state and get advice from a licensed conveyancer or solicitor, a registered tax agent, a licensed mortgage broker or adviser, and other qualified professionals as your situation requires. While care has been taken in preparing this guide, no warranty is given as to its accuracy or completeness, and no liability is accepted for any loss arising from reliance on it.

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